Business Intelligence Overview Report

Executive Sales & Profitability Dashboard – Global Superstore

Prepared by: Enoch Tawiah Acquaye, Junior Business Intelligence Analyst | October 2026

What is Business Intelligence?

Business Intelligence (BI) is the set of processes, technologies and practices that an organization uses to collect data from its operations, organize it, analyze it and present it in a form that supports decisions. The term was first used in this sense by IBM researcher Hans Peter Luhn in 1958, and it was popularized by Gartner in the 1990s. Gartner today describes analytics and BI platforms as tools that let organizations model, analyze and visualize data to support informed decisions, integrating sources such as databases, spreadsheets and cloud services into one unified view.

A typical BI workflow has four stages: extracting the data from source systems; transform it by cleaning errors and standardizing formats; model it so that sales, customers, products and dates relate correctly; and present it through reports and dashboards. In BI terms most dashboards are descriptive analytics, answering what happened, and with drill-down they begin to answer why it happened.

Why do organizations use dashboards?

A dashboard is a visual display of the most important information needed to meet specific objectives, arranged on a single screen so it can be absorbed briefly (Few, 2006). Organizations adopt dashboards for four main reasons:

- **A single version of the truth.** Everyone works from the same governed numbers instead of competing spreadsheets.
- **Speed.** Data refreshes automatically, replacing weeks of manual reporting with near-instant views.
- **Self-service.** Managers can filter by year, market or segment themselves without waiting for an analyst.
- **Early warning.** Key performance indicators (KPIs) with clear colour cues expose problems before they become costly.

How dashboards improve decision-making

Dashboards improve decisions by shortening the path from raw data to action:

- **Clarity:** charts reveal patterns, such as seasonality, growth and outliers, that are invisible in thousands of table rows.
- **Prioritization:** KPI cards and rankings show managers which regions, products or customers deserve attention first.
- **Root-cause analysis:** slicers and drill-downs let users move from a headline figure, such as falling margin, to its cause, such as a specific country or discount level.
- **Accountability and alignment:** shared targets and metrics keep teams focused on the same objectives.
- **Evidence over intuition:** organizations that base choices on analysis rather than instinct tend to outperform competitors (Davenport & Harris, 2007).

Business objective of the selected dataset

The Global Superstore dataset represents a retailer selling furniture, office supplies and technology across the world. Its key characteristics are summarized below.

Item	Detail
Source file	Global_Superstore2.csv (51,290 order lines, 24 columns)
Period	1 January 2011 – 31 December 2014
Scale	25,035 orders · 1,590 customers · 147 countries · 7 markets · 13 regions
Products	3 categories, 17 sub-categories
Key measures	Sales, Profit, Quantity, Discount, Shipping Cost

Objective: to give senior management a clear, interactive view of where the company's sales and profit come from across markets, customer segments, product categories and time, and to reveal where discounting, weak product lines or under-performing regions are reducing profitability.

The dashboard is designed to answer seven questions: overall sales performance; which regions earn the most sales and profit; which customer segments contribute most revenue; which categories perform best; which products are most profitable; what trends appear over time; and what actions management should take. The results will support decisions on pricing and discount policy, product ranges, regional investment and growth strategy.

References

Davenport, T. H. & Harris, J. G. (2007) Competing on Analytics: The New Science of Winning. Boston: Harvard Business School Press.

Few, S. (2006) Information Dashboard Design: The Effective Visual Communication of Data. Sebastopol, CA: O'Reilly Media.

Gartner (2026) Analytics and Business Intelligence Platforms – market definition. Gartner Peer Insights. Available at: gartner.com/reviews (Accessed: October 2026).

Luhn, H. P. (1958) 'A Business Intelligence System', IBM Journal of Research and Development, 2(4), pp. 314–319.

Microsoft (n.d.) Power BI documentation – dashboards and reports. Microsoft Learn. Available at: learn.microsoft.com/power-bi (Accessed: October 2026).